THE ROLE OF THE CHURCH IN GOVERNANCE

Inaugural Paper presented on the occasion of the 38th Annual convention of the Canon Law society of Nigeria CLSN

INTRODUCTION

The good news of salvation requires that the Church be present in the world. Christ, our Saviour, "desires all men to be saved and to come to the knowledge of the truth" (1 Tim 2:4). The Church, sharing in mankind's joys and hopes, in its anxieties and sadness, stands with every man and woman of every place and time, to bring them the good news of the Kingdom of God, which in Jesus Christ has come and continues to be present among them. For this reason, the Church is not indifferent to what is decided, brought about or experienced in society; she is attentive to the moral quality, that is, the authentically human and humanizing aspects of social life.

The terminology: **Rerum Novarum** means "of revolutionary change/new things" and was promulgated by Pope Leo XIII in 1891. It is foundational to modern Catholic social teaching.

The paper makes an important distinction: Christ is King, but the Church's mission is not to establish a theocratic State. The Kingdom of God is already present in Christ and the Church yet awaits its fullness. The Church therefore enters public life principally through proclamation of the Gospel, formation of conscience, social action, and the defence of human dignity.

This paper examines the role of the Church in governance through the theological vision of Christ as ***Rex Regum***, King of Kings. Governance is ultimately a question about the human person: who the person is, what the person is worth, what government exists to accomplish, and what limits ought to constrain the exercise of public authority. Where the human person is reduced to a voter, taxpayer, consumer, ethnic subject, political supporter or economic unit, governance inevitably becomes vulnerable to manipulation, exclusion and abuse. The Catholic Church approaches governance from a fundamentally different starting point: the human person is created in the image and likeness of God, possesses an intrinsic and inviolable dignity, and is ordered towards communion with God and others.

The Church's role in governance is neither political domination nor institutional withdrawal. Rather, it is a mission of evangelization, formation of conscience and defence. The church is not simply a religious association attempting to secure influence within the political sphere. She is the sacrament of salvation, the sign and instrument of unity, communion with God and entire church. The Church contributes to governance by helping society recover the truth that every authority is from God **(Romans 13 verse 1)** and exists for the human person and the common good.

The crisis of governance is frequently described in institutional language: corruption, weak institutions, electoral malpractice, insecurity, poor public services, abuse of power, poverty and declining public trust. Yet beneath these institutional failures lies a deeper crisis, a crisis concerning the human person the crisis of sin. *But this world crisis is a crisis of saints*.

The Christian proclamation begins with a radically different sovereignty: Jesus Christ is Lord **(Phillipians 2:11).** Thus the proclamation of Christ as Rex Regum: King of Kings, places every earthly authority under a higher moral horizon. Yet Christ's kingship is radically different from the domination exercised by worldly rulers. His throne is the Cross; His authority is expressed in service; and His greatness manifested, in self-giving love.

REX REGUM: CHRIST AND THE NEW KINGDOM

The Christian understanding of governance begins with Christ.

Scripture declares in **1 Timothy 6:15: "King of kings, and Lord of lords."**

Yet Christ expressly rejected the worldly conception of political domination. When His disciples disputed about greatness, Christ taught: "Whosoever will be great among you, shall be your minister." The Christian concept of authority therefore begins with service.

The Church is not simply a religious association attempting to secure influence within the political sphere. She is the sacramental community called to proclaim the Kingdom of God.

RERUM NOVARUM: THE CHURCH ENTERS THE SOCIAL QUESTION

When Pope Leo XIII promulgated Rerum Novarum in 1891, he confronted a society transformed by industrialisation, economic inequality, exploitation of labour and the concentration of wealth.

It demonstrated that the Church cannot proclaim the dignity of the human person while remaining indifferent to the social structures that either protect or violate that dignity.

The Compendium of the Social Doctrine of the Church (Libreria Editrice Vaticana, Vatican City 2004) para 160 identifies four foundational principles:

the dignity of the human person, the common good, subsidiarity and solidarity. The human person is never a means merely to another person's or institution's end.

Every person possesses an intrinsic dignity because every person is created in the image and likeness of God. The Compendium identifies the inviolable dignity of the human person as the foundation of the Church's social doctrine. It further states that the person is not merely a passive object of social life but its subject, foundation and goal.

This has direct consequences for governance.

A government exists for persons, laws exist for persons, courts exist for persons, public institutions exist for persons, even the economy exists for persons.

Political authority therefore becomes morally illegitimate when it systematically sacrifices persons to institutional interests.

The question that every public policy should answer is therefore: ***What does this policy do to the dignity of the human person?***

The relevance of this principle to Nigeria is striking.

Section 17 of the Constitution of the Federal Republic of Nigeria 1999 expressly provides that the Nigerian social order is founded on freedom, equality and justice. It further states that the sanctity of the human person shall be recognised, human dignity maintained and enhanced, governmental actions humane, and exploitation prevented where it is not for the good of the community.

The constitutional language is remarkably consonant with the fundamental concern of this social doctrine. It envisions governance ordered towards human welfare. The Church, however, approaches the issue from an even deeper foundation***: dignity is not granted by government.***

Government does not manufacture human dignity, the legislature does not create it, our judiciary does not create it, a constitution does not create it. Human dignity in fact, precedes the State. The State can recognise it, protect it or violate it, but it cannot ultimately confer it.

That distinction is crucial.

If dignity comes from the State, the State can take it away.

If dignity comes from the nature of the human person created by God, the State is then under an obligation to protect it.

This brings us to a particularly important question for the Church in Nigeria:

What exactly is the Church's role in governance?

The answer must begin with a necessary distinction.

The Church is not the State, the state is not the Church.

The Church does not possess a mandate to capture political power nor should she become an appendage of political parties. *My kingdom is not of this world*

The Second Vatican Council expressly teaches that the Church is not identified with the political community or bound to any political system. Rather, she is a safeguard of the transcendent character of the human person. History has taught of how much harm it can do.

This distinction is essential.

The Church's role is therefore primarily formative, pastoral and social, rather than partisan.

The Church speaks truth to power because she is not created by power, She can commend good governance without becoming the government, She can criticise injustice without becoming an opposition

party, She can defend human rights without becoming a political movement, She can encourage public officials without becoming their political machinery.

This independence is one of the Church's greatest contributions to public life.

ROLE OF THE CHURCH IN FORMATION OF GOVERNANCE

Throughout Scripture, the prophetic tradition demonstrates that religious faith cannot be separated from questions of justice.

The prophets confronted kings; Nathan confronted David, Elijah confronted Ahab, John the Baptist confronted Herod, Christ confronted structures of hypocrisy and oppression. Christ in the middle of the passion presents us with an iconic scene a dialogue with Pilate that led him to ask difficult questions …***"truth what is truth"***

The Church inherits this prophetic responsibility.

Her prophetic ministry requires her to ask the uncomfortable questions:

Who speaks for the poor? Who protects the vulnerable? Who defends the voiceless? Who ensures that the law serves justice rather than merely power?

And the church has not just the task of asking questions, but doing something within its means.

Romans 15:26 (KJV): "or it hath pleased them of Macedonia and Achaia to make a certain contribution for the poor saints which are at Jerusalem."

Acts 11:29 (KJV): "Then the disciples, every man according to his ability, determined to send relief unto the brethren which dwelt in Judaea."

A Church that refuses to ask these questions risks reducing Christianity to private spirituality.

Pope Francis has similarly emphasised that the Church has a public role extending beyond charitable and educational activities and that she cannot renounce the political dimension of life where the common good and integral human development are concerned.

One of the most important but frequently overlooked contributions of the Church to governance is formation. Good governance ultimately depends upon good citizens all round. Jesus said to the pharisees in **Matthew 23:23 (KJV): "Woe unto you, scribes and Pharisees, hypocrites! for ye pay tithe of mint and anise and cummin, and have omitted the weightier matters of the law, judgment, mercy, and faith: these ought ye to have done, and not to leave the other undone."**

A Christian who learns that every human being bears the image of God should find it increasingly difficult to justify bribery, electoral violence, ethnic discrimination, exploitation or abuse of public office.

This is why the social doctrine of the church cannot remain in books but must rather, become a way of life. The church leaders at every tier should not take this lightly. Our Priests are to normalize the good

habit of revisiting Scriptural principles for everything affair. As it is written in **Rom 10:14(KJV) "...and how shall they believe in him of whom they have not heard? and how shall they hear without a preacher?"**

The first way in which society can be influenced with the help of the Church's social doctrine is to disseminate these teachings of the Church that have been referenced earlier. The second aspect is to underline the ways in which these teachings can be applied in practice, and the third way of influencing society is in a more markedly professional or academic way.. Often it will be necessary to confront new problems that have not arisen in the past. Faithful who are experts in the different social fields (economics, politics, media, education, etc) will need to propose ways to solve them that heed the Church's social teaching.

SUBSIDIARITY: GOVERNANCE FROM THE PERSON UPWARDS

Rerum Novarum, the landmark social encyclical of the Catholic Church issued by Pope Leo XIII on 15 May 1891, offers a particularly important insight into public authority, public office is a trust. The official who controls public resources is a steward, not an owner.

This principle is particularly relevant in developing democracies. A healthy state does not seek to control everything, It rather, creates conditions in which persons and communities can flourish. The Church herself embodies this principle through her network of schools, hospitals, charitable institutions, associations and other communities. Our Governance becomes stronger when citizens are not merely recipients of government services but active participants in social development.

The Church does not teach Christians to withdraw from political life. On the contrary, participation in public life can be an expression of Christian responsibility.

This means that the Christian politician has a vocation.

The Christian civil servant has a vocation.

The Christian judge has a vocation.

The Christian lawyer has a vocation.

The Christian academic has a vocation.

The Christian journalist has a vocation.

The question is therefore not simply:

"Can Christians participate in politics?" The better question is: "What kind of politics should a Christian pursue?"

The answer must be politics ordered towards the common good.

It is however worthy of note that the prophetic credibility of the Church is strengthened when her internal life reflects the principles she proclaims. The ***Pontifical Council for Justice and Peace, Compendium of the***

Social Doctrine of the Church presented at the Vatican on 2 April 2004, states that the Church's social doctrine is concerned with the quality of social life because society concerns the human person, and it identifies the promotion of human dignity as a central task of the Church and the lay faithful. Therefore, the Nigerian Church must move from merely responding to social crises towards helping form the culture that produces good governance.

THE NEW KINGDOM: A DIFFERENT MODEL OF POWER

What, then, does "a new kingdom" mean?

It does not mean replacing the Nigerian Republic with a theocracy.

It is a kingdom in which power becomes service, the poor become persons rather than statistics, the opponent becomes a person whose dignity remains inviolable, and the human person becomes the centre of social concern.

The contemporary relevance of the Church's social doctrine is powerfully demonstrated in ***Fratelli Tutti*** an encyclical letter of Pope Francis, published on 3 October 2020, on the theme of human fraternity and social friendship.

Pope Francis argues that authentic politics must be directed towards the common good and presents political activity as capable of becoming an expression of charity when it works to transform social structures and conditions, a solid movement from compassion towards transformation.

The deeper message is conversion. The problem is not only corrupt politicians, but corrupt culture. Our society cannot consistently condemn corruption in government while tolerating dishonesty in private life.

The new Kingdom, the Rerum Novarum we seek as a church, begins with the conversion of the human heart, but it does not end there. Converted people must also seek the transformation of social structures.

THE ROLE OF THE LAITY IN GOVERNANCE

The lay faithful occupy a unique position in this mission.

The priest has a pastoral mission, the bishop has an episcopal responsibility, the canon lawyer has a juridical vocation, but the Catholic layperson who serves in government, law, medicine, business, academia, media or civil society enters directly into the temporal order.

If the Church is to make a meaningful contribution to governance, the Church must ensure that she does not become what she criticizes. When ecclesial platforms become political campaign platforms, the spread of the Gospel suffers. The church must remember at all times, that her loyalty is to Christ.

The ultimate contribution of Catholic social doctrine to governance can therefore be summarised in one proposition: Governance must become human again. This means:

A justice system that sees a person before a case number.

A prison system that sees a person before an inmate number.

A hospital that sees a patient before a statistic.

A government that sees a citizen before a voter.

A public servant who sees office as stewardship rather than entitlement.

A Church that sees the blood of christ running through the vein of each person.

This is what the dignity of the human person demands.

CONCLUSION

More than a century later, the Church's social doctrine has developed into a coherent body of principles centred upon the dignity of the human person, the common good, subsidiarity and solidarity.

The contemporary challenge is to translate these principles into the realities of governance.

Nigeria does not merely need new policies, rather leaders who are well formed and struggle to acquire the virtues and practice them.

The church is to announce a Kingdom whose King is Christ, forms consciences according to the Gospel, defend the dignity of every human person, form citizens for service and stand with the poor and vulnerable.

"Pure religion and undefiled before God and the Father is this, To visit the fatherless and widows in their affliction, and to keep himself unspotted from the world." James 1:27

The Church's task, therefore, is to keep reminding the world of this truth, and to embody it.

IKECHUKWU ONUOMA SAN

Managing Partner

Obra Legal LP